



How to submit public comments on E-Rate to the FCC

E-Rate Is Under Threat

On June 25, 2026, the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) released a proposal that raises questions about the future of the federal E-Rate program, which helps public libraries and schools afford broadband and Wi-Fi services. If E-Rate funding is eliminated or reduced, libraries across the country could face difficult choices between maintaining internet access and funding other essential services.

Your Voice Matters

Every comment submitted to the FCC is reviewed by agency staff. The FCC considers the comments received in developing final rules. The more library supporters and library workers share how E-Rate supports their communities, the better FCC decision-makers can understand the real-world impact of this program and the consequences of ending or weakening it.

File comments on E-Rate

Deadline: Tuesday, October 13, 2026, 11:59 pm (ET)

All comments officially become part of the public record. Note that any comments that you submit will be made public, including any personally identifiable information in the body of your submission. This includes information on letterhead.

Step 1: Draft

Use the template below to develop your letter, customizing it with authentic stories and data from your library to illustrate the impact of E-Rate. You may wish to submit your letter on your organization's letterhead.

Step 2: Submit

Enter your information, attaching your letter, on the FCC's Electronic Comment Filing System: <https://www.fcc.gov/ecfs/filings/standard>. You **must** include the docket numbers for all four proceedings related to E-Rate (26-133; 13-184; 21-93; 21-455). Type in the numbers one by one, pressing the tab key after each docket number.

Step 3: Share

Comments are usually published within 48 hours. Share your comments with your professional network and encourage them to submit comments as well! Also, send your letter to mjanicki@alawash.org to let ALA know you've taken action.

FCC filing interface preview:

The screenshot shows the FCC filing interface. At the top, the URL is fcc.gov/ecfs/filings/standard. The header includes the FCC logo and navigation links: [Filings & Proceedings](#), [Submit a FILING](#) (highlighted), [Check Filing STATUS](#), and [User HELP](#). Below the header, there are three tabs: [Standard Filing](#) (selected), [Express Comment](#), and [Non-Docketed Filing](#).

Submit a Standard Filing

The main content area shows a three-step process: 1. FILING, 2. REVIEW, and 3. CONFIRMATION. The first step, FILING, is active.

***Proceeding(s): Select the FCC Proceeding(s) to which your filing refers**

26-133 × 13-184 × 21-93 × 21-455 ×

***Name(s) of Filer(s): Enter the name(s) of the persons or entities whose views the filing represents**

Template

IMPORTANT: The following is a template. Personalize your letter to the FCC.

[Date]

[Use Official Letterhead If Applicable]

Filer Name

Organization's or Individual's Address]

SUBMITTED ELECTRONICALLY VIA ECFS

Ms. Marlene H. Dortch
Secretary
Federal Communications Commission
45 L Street NE
Washington, DC 20554

Re: Ensuring Children's Safe Use of Screens and E-Rate-Funded Services, WC Docket No. 26-133

Modernizing the E-Rate Program for Schools and Libraries, WC Docket No. 13-184

Establishing the Emergency Connectivity Fund to Close the Homework Gap, WC Docket No. 21-93

Promoting Fair and Open Competitive Bidding in the E-Rate Program, WC Docket No. 21-455

Dear Ms. Dortch:

Introduce your library, where you are, and who you serve.

The [Insert Name of Organization Here] is in [Insert Location Here], a [Insert Location Type e.g. Rural, Suburban, Urban AND Optional Description – you may want to include a description of your community] that serves [Insert Population Served, Number of Card Holders and/or Other Population Metric] in/across [Insert Number of Locations].

Introduce the issue– saving E-Rate-and why you are writing the letter.

I am/We are writing to you regarding the Federal Communications Commission's (FCC) Notice of Proposed Rulemaking and Further Notice of Proposed Rulemaking on the E-Rate

program¹. When E-Rate began in the late 1990s, most libraries and schools had little or no internet access. Today, libraries and schools across the nation, including *[Insert Name of Organization Here]*, have reliable internet access year after year because of E-Rate. Without E-Rate funding, we will have to cut core services, programs, and operations to maintain the internet service our community requires.

Personalize your letter with authentic examples of library services, stories, and/or local statistics demonstrating how your library and community benefit from E-Rate funds. If you have specific numbers for the metrics, include them.

There are still members of our community who cannot afford home internet access and will continue to rely on the library to stay connected *[Include Community Metrics/Statistics, If Known, That Support Need for Internet Access e.g. percentage of community who are unconnected or underconnected, do not have computer device, etc. AND/OR Provide a Story that Illustrates Community Need.]* [Note: The FCC has state-by-state USF fact sheets and other data available available on their website: <https://www.fcc.gov/document/fact-sheet-impact-universal-service-fund>]

[Insert Name of Organization Here] received *[Insert the Amount of E-Rate Funding You Receive]*. Last year, approximately *[If Known # of People Who Visited Your Organization]* walked through our doors. Our network supported *[If Known # of Public Computer Sessions]* public computer sessions, *[If Known # of Wi-Fi Sessions]* Wi-Fi sessions, and *[If Known # of One-on-one Computer Help]* one-on-one technology coaching help. Our users checked out *[# of materials]* books, videos, magazines, audiobooks, and other resources and attended *[If Known # of People who Attended Programs]* programs. All of these services and programs rely on internet access.

Option 1: Our community uses the internet to participate in a wide range of services and programs *the library offers*, such as searching the collection, applying for a job, co-working, studying, attending computer classes, receiving one-on-one technology support, and more. Without these funds, our community will face unnecessary barriers to attending school, finding jobs, accessing healthcare, starting or growing businesses, and more.

¹ *Ensuring Children's Safe Use of Screens and E-Rate-Funded Services*, WC Docket No. 26-133, *Modernizing the E-Rate Program for Schools and Libraries*, WC Docket No. 13-184, *Establishing the Emergency Connectivity Fund to Close the Homework Gap*, WC Docket No. 21-93, *Promoting Fair and Open Competitive Bidding in the E-Rate Program*, WC Docket No. 21-455, Notice of Proposed Rulemaking and Further Notice of Proposed Rulemaking, FCC 26-41 (rel. June 26, 2026).

Option 2: *Highlight the Most Popular/Impactful Services Your Library Provides and Share Stories: How Have People In Your Community Used the Internet to Support Their Daily Lives or Improve Their Situation.*]

We have seen how internet access has helped our community meet their educational and professional goals.

Examples:

- *A recently laid-off woman worked with the Digital Navigator to learn how to write a resume, search for and apply for jobs, and received coaching to prepare for interviews. She found and accepted a position.*
- *A veteran participated in the entrepreneur bootcamp and successfully launched a business. He still attends workshops at the library to learn about tools and strategies that can help him grow his business.*
- *Three college students are attending classes remotely – they meet at the library weekly to attend class because they have problems connecting to the class using their home internet.*
- *The nearest hospital is a 75-mile drive. The library's telehealth room allows members of our community to attend doctor's appointments closer to home. More than X people have used this room in the last year.*
- *Are there programs you offer that would not be possible without E-Rate internet services? What is it and what impact have you seen?*

Describe the potential harms to/impact on your library were it to lose E-Rate support. Below are examples that can help you illustrate the potential impact of these cuts. If possible, share a story that illustrates the potential harms/impacts the cuts would have on your community:

- *Provide concrete examples of programs and/or services that would be cut or canceled due to a lack of funding, e.g., reduce the collections budget, cancel a program, not replace out-of-date or broken computer equipment, etc.*
- *How would you need to re-allocate your budget to pay for internet access? How difficult would that be?*
- *How would reduced support affect your organization's future connectivity needs and programs? If the library has increased, or is planning to increase, its bandwidth or upgrade its internet connections due to increased community need, how will these cuts impact your plans? How will reduced internet bandwidth impact community access?*

E-Rate is essential for reliable broadband speeds and for regular network maintenance, safety, and security. The library can't operate without the internet. If the FCC terminates or

limits E-Rate funding, our library will be forced to reduce programs and services in order to continue providing internet access.

Wrap up: Remind the FCC why E-Rate is important to you and your community. Ask them to continue supporting E-Rate now and into the future.

E-Rate supported broadband connections enable libraries, like ours, to provide digital literacy training, internet access, and technology support, putting personal goals within reach of everyone in our community: attending school, finding a job, accessing healthcare, connecting with family, starting or growing businesses, and more.

E-Rate is an essential program, and **I/we** ask for the FCC's continued commitment to ensuring that libraries and schools across the nation have access to these federal funds needed to provide secure, scalable, future-ready connectivity that supports the current and evolving needs of our community.

Respectfully,

[Signature]

[Your Name]

[Your Title]